

Attending a concert was something very new to me—especially attending one that revolved around Western art music. However, the program Post-Evening Song Recital performed by the Hunter College Chamber Singers did not disappoint, as they blew out any expectations I had and left me with a whole new appreciation for musicians. The Chamber Singers (performing forces) are a choir ranging from 24–30 mixed individuals from various ethnic backgrounds. They tend to hone in on performing choral music, which refers to music that is written for a group of singers divided into different voice parts such as soprano, alto, tenor, and more. This diverse group of singers focused on performing the multifaceted repertoire from the Middle Ages, Renaissance, and Modern Periods. As such, the songs performed within this program's concert are much more complex than what one might assume, as they all unify to make a collective theme, with each piece having its own relevance and novelty.

Upon examining the repertoire, there seems to be overarching themes of hope, tranquility, and spiritual resonance. Songs such as *Pange Lingua Gloriosi*, *O Sing Joyfully*, *Adoramus Te*, and *Ani Ma'amin* are rooted in sacred/devotional tradition. These songs are made to express faith, hope, and worship to make the listener have a spiritual connection to a greater deity, or at the very least, help relax one's mind and soul. Others, such as *Mo Li Hua* and *Bright Morning Stars*, come from a tradition with more of a secular origin. Yet, they still convey the same message of spirituality, just similar to the rest of the sacred songs.

As previously mentioned, this program contains songs that stretch from a long period of time, from the Medieval, Renaissance, and Modern Periods, along with some being within a sacred tradition, and others within a more secular worldview. The piece in particular that I will be analyzing is *Sunday*, from *Sunday in the Park with George*. This piece is made within the 20th-21st century and derives from a history of musical theatre, as the song is meant to develop characters in a story. Within this context, the genre mostly fits as a choral arrangement, as the origin of the song itself is within a theatrical setting, but this program presents it as a choral work. Now, considering this piece was made in the 20th/21st century, I envision it possessing a secular genre, along with immense diversity in terms of timbre, texture, and instrumentation as a whole. This time period is known for having an abundance of creativity and new combinations of music that we didn't know were possible to create. Hamilton by Lin-Manuel Miranda does a great job at displaying this by incorporating hip-hop elements such as beatboxing, as well as using contemporary instruments like the electric bass, and putting even more elements into one giant polyphonic concoction. Overall, I expect for there to be a mix of elements that previous time periods didn't have access to, which accentuates how flashy the piece really is.

Shockingly enough, *Sunday* was a piece with captivating elements that ended up going outside of my expectations. Firstly, the texture of this piece was leaning more toward the monophonic side. The ladies of the group were mainly leading the melody, while the men in the beginning were working on keeping harmonic support, while singing in the same rhythm. However, near the ending of this piece, this monophonic trend began to disappear, as a unison blossomed throughout. The more time went on, one by one, the more members within the choir began to join in on the unison occurring in the female group. At one point, it was every member singing the same note, at the same time in perfect unison at a mezzo forte, undoubtedly being the

most gratifying part of the composition. Another element that caught me off guard was the timbre of the piece. For a composition being in the 21st century, I expected to hear a vast majority of instruments to make the piece more appealing/complex, yet the only instrument implemented into this composition was a piano. The beginning of the composition is the only interval within the piece where timbre is most prominent, as the baritone/bass contrasted heavily with the sopranos of the group. Yet, returning to what was earlier referenced, the more the song carried on, the more in unison everything went with one another, not leaving any difference in sound as everyone sang as one entire group. The only aspect that met my expectation of the composition was its secular origin, as there is no worship or spiritual essence being emphasized. The remainder, by contrast, went outside of my expectations as the song was performed in a simple manner, with no fancy incorporations inside of it to make one instantly recognize that the piece is from the 21st century.

*Sunday* is a great form of musical work that embodies great institutional and socio-political importance. To give context, the Reagan administration in the 1980s decided to cut funding on multiple art institutions (e.g., NEA), which put pressure on many artists. Artists under this time of financial instability felt obligated to create work that was marketable and appealing, not just meaningful. This entire mindset and shift in the art world was critiqued by *Sunday*, as it focuses on George (the protagonist) feeling isolated and misunderstood, serving as a reflection of how many artists felt disconnected from commercial art systems. Shifting focus to the sociopolitical context, due to the Reagan administration cutting funding, the 1980s were marked by consumerism and a growing love for profit and money grabs. Many artists across the U.S. stopped caring about creativity and their art and only wanted to make their music connect to consumers rather than make it from their heart. Yet, George is a character who embodies an artist

who chooses personal vision over public acceptance, mirroring the struggles artists went through during this time. In addition, this decision by George gave inspiration to artists who decided they'd rather be authentic than sell out their creativity for financial gain. George is a great character within the piece who served as an exemplar to all artists out there during this financial crisis, shining hope to those who aspire to stay expressive and innovative.

As a closing thought, this program did not disappoint regarding its musical choices and musical performance. The performers themselves were a diverse group, and the song genres and time periods were varied. To top it all off, the pieces within the program carried great importance for their time period, and are still applicable to us today, further showcasing how great this recital was in terms of both entertainment and significance.